dislike of the growing trend among the Mappilas to deliberately seek martyrdom by killing a Hindu landlord.

Sayyid Sanulla Makti Thangal died in 1912 and so never lived to see the outbreak of the First World War and the rise of the Khilafat separatist movement that convulsed the Muslim population in India. The movement eventually ran out of steam as Turkey moved towards secularism and the abolition of the caliphate. Even so, in Malabar it led to the setting up of local Khilafat Committees whose prime aim was nothing less than an independent Muslim nation in Malabar. This inevitably created tensions between the Muslim Mappilas and the Kerala Provincial Congress Committee, dominated by Tamil Brahmins and Malabar Nairs. Despite these differences, the central All-India Khilafat Committee joined with the Hindu-dominated Indian National Congress in 1920 in a nationwide civil disobedience campaign that became known as the Non-cooperation Movement. In March of that year Mahatma Gandhi addressed a Khilafat meeting in Bombay and declared it incumbent on all Muslims to rebel against the British government in India and to follow their religious leaders. Gandhi intended his speech to be taken as referring to his allies the Ali brothers and their platform of non-violence, but in Malabar his speech was seen as an endorsement of their local religious leadership and their local aims.[16]

I am puzzled by the extent to which what followed is represented in some quarters as part of India's freedom struggle against the British. I share the majority view that it was primarily about land – that what the British authorities termed the 'Mopla outrages' of 1920–21 were at heart a desperate attempt by Mappila tenant farmers and landless labourers to destroy the existing landlord system by killing Nair and Nambudiri landlords, a movement that rapidly escalated into widespread acts of terrorism directed at the non-Muslim community in general.